

Child and Co.

No. 139

THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

April 2026

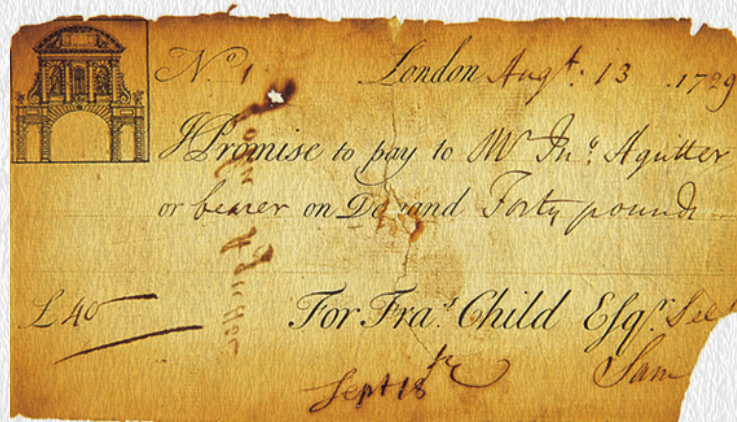
Child and Co. of 1 Fleet Street was a well-known private bank. Its origins went back to a goldsmith, Robert Blanchard, who traded on the Strand, and Francis Child, who joined him in 1665. The business moved to the western end of Fleet Street in 1673, where the shop was identified by the sign of the Marygold.

In 1677, Francis Child was admitted to partnership and, in 1681, married Blanchard's stepdaughter, inheriting the business. In 1689, he was knighted and appointed "jeweller in ordinary" to King William III. Supported by the Earl of Dorset, he regularly advanced large sums to the Treasury. The bank built connections with lawyers in the Temple and many Oxford colleges, helping it survive several banking crises. The business was subsequently managed by Francis Child's sons and then by his grandson, Robert Child.

Robert's son, Francis Child, had only one child, Sarah Anne, who was thus a considerable heiress. The story goes that in 1782 the Earl of Westmoreland, a client, asked Mr Child what he would do if he wished to marry a girl whose father withheld consent.

"Why, I'd run away with her," came the reply. Days later, Sarah Anne, aged 17, eloped with the Earl towards Gretna Green. Mr Child sent a trusted servant in pursuit. He caught up with them at Rokeby in Yorkshire and delivered his message.

"Shoot, my lord," cried Sarah. The Earl shot the horse. When Mr Child arrived soon after, he was so affected by the death of his favourite horse that he called off the chase. He did, however, disinherit his daughter, settling the inheritance on her first child.



That child was Sarah Sophia, who in 1804 married George Villiers, later the 5th Earl of Jersey. She inherited ownership of the bank in 1806 and remained senior partner until her death in 1867. Although she rarely attended in person, she took an active interest in its affairs and was a leading London hostess.

The bank experienced one major problem during her tenure when she proposed her cousin, Vere Fane, as a partner. Other partners resisted because it had long been customary for vacancies to be filled by promoting staff. The dispute attracted press attention and may have caused some loss of confidence among customers. A compromise was eventually reached after litigation. Following Lady Jersey's death, the historic practice resumed until the 1920s.

There is a vivid description in Charles Dickens's *A Tale of Two Cities* of Tellson's Bank, believed to be based on Child and Co.

In 1874, Temple Bar was found to be structurally unsound and removed. As the bank shared a party wall with the Bar, this

provided an opportunity to rebuild the premises in a modern building, which still stands today but is currently empty.

Small private banks faced increasing competition from joint-stock banks with broader capital bases, and many disappeared by 1900. Child and Co. survived and even opened a branch in Oxford for a time.

In 1924, the executors of the 8th Earl of Jersey sold the bank to Glyn, Mills, Currie, Holt and Co. During the 1950s and 1960s, new services were introduced and accounting was mechanised. The bank finally closed in 2022.